

Europe's new Ukraine crisis

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【メール原文】

Presented by AMD By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Headed to Ireland this week? Drop us a line. In today's Playbook: — EU trade czar M

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Headed to Ireland this week? Drop us a line.

In today's Playbook:

- EU trade czar Maroš Šefčovič discusses plans to cut China's exports to the bloc.
- Frank Furedi takes leave of the defunded MCC think tank and plans his next move.
- Faces in the crowd: Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Andrii Sybiha, Pedro Sánchez, Kyriakos Mitsotakis, Benedikta von Seherr-Thoss, Sarah Knafo, Kaja Kallas, Salvis Draviņš and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian explain why the EU thinks it needs a new way of tackling China's unfair trade practices.

****A message from AMD: Open standards, interoperability, and supplier diversity will be the cornerstones of Europe's AI future. They drive innovation and choice, strengthen resilience, and provide opportunities to adopt and integrate novel technologies and new capabilities. Read how open technology stack drives choice across hardware, software and deployment models as the EU seeks to build sovereign AI capabilities.****

DRIVING THE DAY

UKRAINE'S ALLIES TO SPAR OVER FUNDING AND AIR DEFENSE: Ukraine's Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha is set to press allies in Ireland this week to deliver urgently needed air defenses and fill a funding gap that has led to a \$27 billion shortfall at Kyiv's defense ministry.

The call will prompt the allies — the 27 EU members plus Norway, Canada and the U.K. — to thrash out how best to meet Kyiv's needs as Russia shifts its tactics to near-continuous bombardment.

Emergency, again: The near-daily drone and missile attacks have put Ukraine at the top of the EU's back-to-school in-tray. The funding problem has become unavoidable after Ukraine's President

Volodymyr Zelenskyy raised the alarm about the cash needed to keep his defense ministry ticking over.

Finger-pointing: Greece and Spain, which lag other allies in the numbers of interceptors offered, are set to be at the sharp end of calls to boost air defenses. Spanish PM Pedro Sánchez vowed in March to give Ukraine five Patriot interceptors but Greece has given none. PM Kyriakos Mitsotakis has even boasted that Athens (which has just inked a €3 billion air defense deal with Israel) has “resisted” pressure to deliver Patriots.

Gearing up: Foreign and defense ministers “will definitely speak up about this ... It’s not fair for some countries to bear most of the burden,” said an EU diplomat who was granted anonymity to talk about the delicate negotiations.

In addition to the defense ministry issue, Ukraine faces a €45 billion budget shortfall next year, which was meant to be met by non-EU Ukraine allies when European leaders agreed on a €90 billion loan. Despite strong financial aid from Norway and the U.K., contributions from other G7 Ukraine backers including Canada and Japan, along with the IMF, aren’t yet filling the final third.

Up-front money: Zelenskyy is calling to bring forward part of the EU loan, but the response from EU countries has been muted. Some want to reopen discussions on the use of Russia’s frozen assets, in what one diplomat said was a signal to the Commission to come up with new proposals to address Belgium’s legal concerns. But even those wanting to revive that debate agree it’s a tough sell.

Pressed on bringing forward the loan, diplomats from three so-called frugal countries left the door open. “We are a frugal country when it comes to the MFF, but for support to Ukraine we are completely generous and flexible,” said one of them.

ALSO IN FOCUS: EEAS reform, to be discussed Wednesday during a special “Gymnich” session of the bloc’s foreign affairs ministers. Expect proposals from top diplomat Kaja Kallas on how to revamp the foreign policy branch — as well as grumbling from countries saying this isn’t the time to change the way the EU works.

The bottom line: Ukraine is back to being a flashing red emergency for the EU and other allies during this rentrée.

BIG AND BREAKING

DUBLIN PUSHES TO REVIVE MFF TALKS: Ireland is stepping up efforts to unblock talks on the EU’s next seven-year budget , with governments split over the size and aims of the spending plan, Gregorio Sorigi reports.

LE PEN’S BALANCING ACT: Far-right leader Marine Le Pen is betting that she can broaden her appeal among traditional center-right voters without backpedaling on promises made to her core supporters, Marion Solletty reports.

BACK IN FROM THE COLD: The Trump administration’s decision to allow Russia to attend the G20 is riling European allies , who want to keep Moscow isolated over the war in Ukraine.

SPACE SECURITY: Ursula von der Leyen will deliver a major speech on space at a Paris conference on Sept. 10, as the Commission prepares to unveil its European Space Shield to protect the bloc’s satellites, Antoaneta Roussi, Gabriel Gavin and Jacopo Barigazzi report.

EUROPE'S DATA-CENTER REVOLT: Energy-hungry data centers are being built across Europe — and resistance to them is growing , Zia Weise reports.

EU TRADE CHIEF'S MESSAGE TO CHINA

OCTOBER DEADLINE FOR CHINA: The EU is exploring ways to persuade Beijing to rein in its exports to the bloc as the European Commission comes under pressure to reduce its €1 billion-a-day trade deficit with China — and to show EU leaders it can deliver results.

Adjusting the balance: “Mechanically ... what’s needed is the increase of European products to China ... We also need to look at how to manage better the Chinese exports to the European Union,” EU trade chief Maroš Šefčovič told my colleague Camille Gijs Monday.

Why it matters: National leaders want the Commission to show results from its engagement with Beijing by mid-October. Two months ago, EU members urged Brussels to come up with new tools to reduce the trade deficit, as manufacturers of chemicals and cars closed plants and cut jobs, under pressure from cheaper Chinese imports.

Tick tock: Šefčovič will speak with his Chinese counterpart Wang Wentao by videoconference in mid-September before visiting Beijing in early October, he said. EU negotiators are in China this week for talks that are “very open, very tough,” the commissioner said, with “all topics ... on the table.”

Changing tack: Brussels is edging toward a more interventionist China policy — and taking a page from Washington’s book. Rather than relying primarily on traditional trade defenses once Chinese goods reach Europe, the approach increasingly focuses on a broader management of trade flows between the two sides.

“We are working with very concrete proposals. Let’s see how our Chinese counterparts would react to them,” Šefčovič said. If there’s no action in response to the EU’s concerns, then the bloc would look to make full use of its trade defenses and shut off its markets, he said.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Today and tomorrow, Wicklow, in Ireland, will host a Gymnich. But what does that mean? A Gymnich is an informal meeting of EU foreign affairs ministers (informal in an EU context means a less rigid agenda, with no formal decisions made or votes taken). There are two such meetings held each year, hosted by the country holding the rotating presidency of the Council of the EU and chaired by Kallas. The name comes from Schloss Gymnich, a castle in Germany where the first such meeting was held, in 1974.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked whether you’re willing to pay more for your shopping to prop up EU industry. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

THINK TANK TROUBLE

BATTLE FOR THE BRUSSELS BUBBLE: The team behind MCC Brussels won't be silenced. The EU's most talked-about right-wing think tank, which lost its funding from Budapest following Viktor Orbán's defeat, may be shuttered, but the group's director is already planning his next move.

Watch this space: Frank Furedi quit as MCC director yesterday , telling Playbook the move was the first step in "the process of mobilizing support [for] eventually launching a new initiative" with alternative funding.

What happened: The group, which set out to challenge "mainstream" thinking on climate, migration and gender issues, was almost entirely reliant on a multimillion-euro grant from its Hungarian sister organization. That dried up when Prime Minister Péter Magyar took over in May.

Gracious hosts: MCC Brussels was the organizer of events on populism, transgender rights, and "the future of the West," and also a "Freedom Ball" for the city's right-wing movers and shakers, complete with a symphony orchestra and champagne reception. But it had its membership of the EU's Transparency Register suspended in a dispute over registration and it has been accused by Magyar of being part of Orbán's network of influence.

Daddy Trump? The U.S. government has publicly said it wants to support MAGA-friendly partners in Europe — Reuters reported overnight that the Trump administration had earmarked \$4 million to bolster right-wing media. It's this kind of support that Furedi's new initiative could tap into. "I'm happy to get money from anywhere, Americans included," he said, while adding that "we don't want strings attached."

"And that's the problem, I think potentially, with the Americans ... they are lovely people but whether they are going to simply allow us to work in the way that we've been accustomed to [remains] to be seen," he said.

****Yesterday marked the launch of our new POLITICO Surge newsletter, a free global newsletter tracking how rising power demand is reshaping energy politics, infrastructure and industry. Sign up here .****

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

GERMAN FAR-RIGHT TESTING GROUND: Alternative for Germany is in striking distance of an election victory in Saxony-Anhalt that it hopes will be a springboard to power nationally.

MODI PRESSES PUTIN: Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi told Russian President Vladimir Putin to end the war in Ukraine for the sake of humanity during a meeting in Kyrgyzstan on Monday.

FOREIGN ACTORS SUSPECTED IN POLISH FIRE: Prosecutors investigating a fire at a factory operated by a drone component maker in Skarżysko-Kamienna say the incident was an arson attack involving foreign intelligence services , Daria Zakharova explains.

DEATH OF BALLADUR: French President Emmanuel Macron described former French PM Edouard Balladur, who has died at the age of 97, as someone who "devoted his life to the Fifth Republic."

READ LIKE KAJA KALLAS: What the ambitious reading list of the EU's top diplomat reveals about her influences and intellectual approach .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Partly cloudy, top of 22C.

THE SCHUMAN JOBS ROUNDABOUT: Officials and diplomats are heading back from their holidays and, while that giant concrete disk at the heart of the EU Quarter hasn't moved in the time they've been away, the faces around it are changing. So — who's coming back to a different role?

Another EEAS exit: Leading diplomat Benedikta von Seherr-Thoss, currently the European External Action Service's managing director for peace, security and defense, will move to the Commission, joining its Directorate-General for Defence Industry and Space (DG DEFIS).

Riga rotation: Salvis Draviņš is moving to Brussels to become Latvia's deputy permanent representative and Coreper I ambassador, after having previously served as sherpa for former Prime Minister Evika Siliņa. He takes the role from Reinis Brusbārdis, who becomes Latvia's ambassador to the EU.

Kyiv colleagues: Former Ukrainian Deputy Prime Minister Taras Kachka is expected to present his credentials at the end of the month as his country's new ambassador to the EU, taking over from long-time envoy Vsevolod Chentsov in a direct job swap.

Stras-ful job? Daniel Köster, EPP group head of press, starts a new role today as the European Parliament's press officer for German media and the International Trade Committee.

AXIS OF INFLUENCE: New public affairs consultancy Axis Advisors, which launches with a glitzy do this evening, is promising advice boosted by AI built for the Brussels bubble. The firm's founders are Sebastian Vos (previously a partner at FGS Global), Claire Boussagol (alumna of Euractiv and POLITICO), Julia Harrison (previously of FTI Consulting), Michelle B. O'Neill (Volvo and Apple) and Nikos Stathopoulos (RSBD Strategies). Those attending the launch can expect branded blue (!) ice cubes.

BRUEGEL CHANGES: Simone Tagliapietra starts in his new role as deputy director of Bruegel today; on Nov. 11, Katharina Bergant will also join Bruegel as deputy director. The appointments were announced earlier this year by the Brussels-based think tank.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz has used a low-key visit to Quedlinburg to renew his warning about the risks of a far-right victory in Saxony-Anhalt.

Paris: Reconquêt MEP Sarah Knafo is doing the media rounds today ahead of a promotional tour for her book — all the while ruling herself out as a presidential candidate.

London: Andy Burnham will give a speech to MPs today to kick off a frenzied parliamentary term.

Washington: The Democrats' summer of squabbling isn't quite over, with New Hampshire voters facing a week of challenges pitting frontrunners against progressive upstarts.

Canberra: Anthony Albanese is at the Pacific Islands Forum in Palau today amid speculation that China was behind the eleventh-hour cancellations of regional leaders.

AGENDA

- Kaja Kallas chairs the two-day informal meeting of foreign affairs ministers (Gymnich) in Wicklow, Ireland, at 8:30 a.m., with the participation of Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič; Kallas will front a joint press conference with Irish Foreign Minister Helen McEntee at 2:30 p.m.
- NATO Deputy Secretary-General Radmila Shekerinska visits Ireland.
- European Council President António Costa meets European Commissioner for Energy and Housing Dan Jørgensen.
- European Parliament President Roberta Metsola hosts an informal breakfast with the EU members' permanent representatives at 9:30 a.m.
- European Council President António Costa meets Executive Chair of ArcelorMittal Lakshmi Mittal.
- Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall receives Thuringia Environment Minister Tilo Kummer.
- Youth Commissioner Glenn Micallef participates in the Youth Policy Dialogue "How to make Arctic youth participation more inclusive."

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEP Milan Brglez; European Commission's Matteo Salvai; the Red Letter's Tara Palmeri; POLITICO's Antoaneta Roussi. Slovak Constitution Day.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from AMD: Europe is in a decisive phase in the race to shape its AI future. Building infrastructure that will reinforce long-term autonomy, resilience and competitiveness is an imperative. Choices made now influence who retains leverage, how quickly Europe can respond to change and where the value created by AI ultimately resides. Systems built on open standards and interoperability give institutions, researchers and enterprises the freedom to adapt, integrate new capabilities and avoid dependence on any single technology path. Supplier diversity strengthens that equation by reducing concentration risk and supporting a more resilient innovation ecosystem. A competitive AI ecosystem depends on an open technology stack that enables choice across hardware, software and deployment models.****

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